THE HARAMSARA AND THE HAJJ

When Abu'l Fazl would write his magisterial biography of Akbar a few years later, he would strive very hard to justify all the earlier foibles of Akbar—his transgressions, his vulnerabilities, and his inconsistencies explained away by an enduring 'veil' behind which he hid his true, divinely inspired nature, to be revealed only after he had thus tested those around him. And if the Padshah, the army, and the empire had to be ordered and tabulated, then so did the much more capricious institution of the harem. In earlier, more capacious, times, the harem was not so separated from the men, and in Kabul, as testified by Gulbadan, 'the women were not veiled, they rode, went on picnics, followed shikar, practiced archery'. It was from the time that Fatehpur Sikri was built, and Abu'l Fazl conjured up a perfect, secluded space, that the women of the Mughal Empire became much more invisible, assigned for the first time to quarters separate and apart. When they were written about at all, as we have seen, which was only very rarely, they were now all 'pillars of chastity' and 'cupolas of chastity'. And, yet, despite the very considerable effort expended by Abu'l Fazl, there were times when that veil was rent aside, when the shadowy, insubstantial presence of the Mughal women grew dense and full of purpose. One of the most extraordinary instances of the women of the Mughal harem stepping far beyond their designated cloistered space was the royal women's hajj of 1575.

Royal women had gone on the hajj before, and we have noted Bega Begum's journey in the previous decade, but the royal hajj of 1575 differed in the scale of the enterprise, the number of women involved, and the elaborate arrangements made for them. According to Abu'l Fazl, Gulbadan had 'long ago made a vow to visit the holy places' and now that the Portuguese 'had become submissive and obedient', performing the hajj pilgrimage had become a reality. Apart from Gulbadan, the large party included two daughters of Kamran, Sultanam Begum, the wife of Askari who had looked after the child Akbar when he had been held hostage by his uncles, a granddaughter and a stepdaughter of Gulbadan, a widow of Babur, three dependents of Humayun (about one of whom we know the charming